



TRAVEL POLICY

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Document Revision History

Version History

The Head of Operations is responsible for the periodic review of this document

Document Responsibility

Title	Travel Policy
Directorate	Corporate Services
Unit	Operations
Manager	Head of Operations
Applicable to	All Staff

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I POLICY STATEMENT

The World Agroforestry Centre (ICRAF) covers the cost of transportation and other necessary and reasonable expenses incurred by staff whilst undertaking authorized international and local business-related travel, medical evacuation, home leave, education travel, recruitment travel, appointment travel, and repatriation travel.

The Centre will:

- Provide a cash advance, if requested, for the traveller.
- Provide an economy class travel ticket on the least cost most direct route.
- Reimburse actual accommodation cost.
- Provide a non-accountable Meal and Incidentals allowance for meals and incidental expenses.
- Reimburse approved official entertainment costs.

The Travel Guidelines provide, among other details, guidance on what to do before, during and after undertaking official travel, and specifies the responsibilities of the traveller, supervisors, authorized signatories, Finance Support Unit and Travel Offices.

II POLICY OBJECTIVES & GUIDING PRINCIPLES

Objectives

Travel is a major variable expenditure of the Centre. The Travel Policy & Guidelines aim to achieve the following objectives:

- To procure travel and related services efficiently and as cost-effectively as possible.
- To ensure equitable provision of travel and related services to all staff.
- To put in place a system through which travel funds are utilized in a transparent manner, and staff are fully accountable for travel funds allocated to them.
- To offer a set of clearly understood policies and guidelines, which will enable the Centre to manage its travel budget in an optimal manner.

Guiding Principles

The policies and guidelines outlined herein have been put in place to enhance operational efficiency. To successfully achieve the objectives set out above, travellers are expected to demonstrate total honesty in travel-related expenses and claims. The success of this policy depends not only on minimizing the loopholes in the system, but in the culture of trust – embodied in the Centre's core values of professionalism and mutual respect – which we aspire towards as an organization.

III SCOPE

This policy applies to staff members, authorized dependents, seconded staff, trainees, consultants and others undertaking authorized Centre travel.

IV RESPONSIBILITY AND ENFORCEMENT

- All persons involved in the processing of travel claims (e.g. the traveller, Travel Office, finance officers who review budgets and expense claims, supervisors) must

adhere to the travel policies and guidelines.

- All travel must be planned, budgeted for and approved in advance by the relevant supervisor.
- Travellers are expected to exercise good judgement and thriftiness in the use of travel funds.
- Travellers must comply with the Travel Policy, and seek approval from the appropriate authority for any exceptions.
- The Centre covers the expenses mentioned in Section VIII. Expenses not mentioned therein will only be reimbursed upon written authorization from the appropriate supervisor/budget holder. Travellers submitting expenses that are not covered by this policy risk delays in processing their claim, or partial or total forfeiture of reimbursement.
- Supervisors and budget holders must ensure that staff have access to the Travel Policy and Guidelines, prior to approving travel, and associated expense claims.

V TRAVEL PLANNING AND AUTHORIZATION

a) Travel plan for the year

- At the beginning of the year, staff members with approved travel budgets should prepare an annual travel schedule.
- The schedule should include proposed dates of travel, travel destinations, cost estimates and trip objectives.
- Supervisors and directors should refer to this travel schedule when approving travel in the course of the year.

b) Travel outside of the approved travel plan

- Travel that is not part of the approved travel plan can be undertaken if funds are available and if the travel is approved as per the authorization table below.

c) Travel authorization

- Prior authorization is required for all official travel.
- Staff members are required to check with the Head of Human Resources, their entitlement and/or eligibility for home leave travel and family visits before incurring expenses.

Authorization for various types of travel and different groups of staff are as follows:

<u>Type of travel/Person travelling</u>	<u>Authorized signatory</u>
Local travel, i.e., travel within the country of the duty-station	Immediate supervisor/ Country representative
Regional travel, i.e., travel within the region of the duty-station	Regional Coordinator
Travel for the Regional Coordinator	Relevant Director
International travel (outside the region)	Relevant Director
Travel by Directors	Director General

d) Medical evacuation

Medical evacuation will be carried out when a Centre-approved medical practitioner has advised that a medical case cannot be dealt with in the country of the duty station. All international

staff members and their eligible dependents residing at the duty station are eligible for payment of return travel, and associated costs, to the nearest place where the necessary facilities exist. All other regular, full-time staff members and their eligible dependents are eligible for travel and associated costs only to the extent of the normal provisions of the standard medical insurance policy subscribed to by the Centre. Authorization for medical travel can be granted only by the Director General.

e) Classes of travel and financial limits

Under normal circumstances, all staff are expected to travel on the least cost ticket on the most direct and cost-effective route. However, depending on the length of the journey, a traveller may wish to upgrade to a higher class of travel. This will be done on a cost sharing basis between ICRAF and the traveller. The upgrades will require various levels of authorization prior to ticketing – for utilization of higher fares other than the ones recommended by the Travel Office. For details see Travel Guidelines.

f) Internet fares

Whenever a staff member finds an airfare (on the Internet) that may result in significant savings, the staff member should inform the Travel Office. The Travel Office will evaluate the potential savings, compare the cost with other options, and advise the traveller accordingly.

g) Combined business and other travel

The Centre will only cover the business portion of a trip when the trip is combined with personal travel. The traveller must cover any additional cost of airfare, accommodation, meals or other incidentals that may arise from such travel. The same principle would apply if someone stays at a destination longer than is necessary for the purpose of ICRAF business. The difference in price and costs incurred, if any, will be borne by the traveller.

h) Sponsored travel

Where staff members' travel and maintenance costs are covered either partially or fully by another party, staff will be required to make full disclosure of such payments. The Centre will only pay the portion of expenses not covered by other parties, provided that prior approval from the supervisor/budget holder has been obtained for the travel.

ICRAF has documented requirements (see Travel Guidelines) to cover the following:

- Air Travel
- Rental Vehicles
- Personal Vehicles
- Rail, Bus and Taxi Transport
- Travel Advances – This includes cash advances and use of credit cards
- Meal and Incidentals Allowances

i) Managing travel risks

ICRAF will work with national and international like-minded institutions to identify and mitigate travel-related risks to the farthest extent possible. This is to ensure safety of staff while on travel at all times. See Travel Guidelines for details.

j) Travel insurance

Travel insurance is mandatory for all staff who undertake international travel on behalf of the Centre.

VI ACCOMODATION

a) Making hotel reservations

All travellers must consult the Travel Office before making hotel reservations. The Travel Office maintains a list of hotels and other accommodation outlets across the various destinations visited by staff. The Travel Office also checks whether other CG Centres located in similar locations have corporate rates that can be used by ICRAF, before making hotel reservations. See further details on accommodation in the Travel Guidelines.

b) Hotel cancellation

It is the responsibility of the traveller to cancel any room reservation they will not be using. A record of the cancellation number should be kept, in case of billing disputes. If a staff member fails to cancel a reservation in a timely fashion, they may be held responsible for any cancellation fees.

VII TRAVEL EXPENSES

a) Travel expense claims

Travel expense claims (TECs), for all types of travel, must be submitted within 10 working days of returning to the staff member's duty station. Expenses not properly supported by documents or not covered by travel entitlements may be rejected by ICRAF. Claims are normally credited to the staff member's personal account or settled in the currency of the duty station, if requested by the staff member. Amounts due to ICRAF must be reimbursed in cash or by cheque when submitting the travel expense claim.

b) Business meals and entertainment

Where a staff member pays for someone else's meal or entertains them while they are conducting official business, such costs will be reimbursed when supported by an approved expense report. Fiscal prudence and common sense should be used. Expenditures determined to be "lavish" will not be reimbursed.

Claims for business meals must include the date, the name of the establishment, the nature of business conducted, and the names and business affiliations of all present.

In general, employees should not use their budgets to entertain or pay for the meal expenses of other ICRAF employees. The cost of meals will not be reimbursed if the meal is already provided and paid for as part of conference/seminar registration fees.

c) Other expenses

- Reasonable laundry expenses will be reimbursed subject to submission of receipts.
- If a staff member falls ill during official travel, expenses are catered for against the corporate travel insurance, any costs not covered hereunder will be reimbursed for periods of sick leave. Hospitalization expenses will be reimbursed as per the Centre medical scheme.
- Expenses for meals while on home leave or education travel will be reimbursed only if the travel involves an unavoidable stop-over.
- Expenses not mentioned herein will only be reimbursed upon written authorization from the appropriate supervisor/budget holder.

d) Corporate credit cards

The Centre under the authorization of the Director, Corporate Services or their designate may approve use of corporate cards in travel and other areas of ICRAF's operations. During travel, the corporate cardholder may use the card to pay for accommodation and other travel expenses.

Unless prior approval is obtained from the Director of Corporate Services and sufficient funds to fully cover the personal expenditure is deposited with ICRAF, the card shall not under any circumstances be used for private transactions or to pay for goods or gifts that are not strictly necessary for the mission. It must not be used for any unauthorized upgrading to another class of travel. See Travel Guidelines for further details.

e) Issuance of foreign currency

Government regulations and/or agreements between the Centre and host governments will apply for issuance and refund of foreign currency for travel.

All eligible travellers on international mission, seminars abroad or group courses abroad will receive their advances in foreign currency. All expenses need to be justified upon the traveller's return and unspent balances must be returned in cash or by personal cheque. Refunds may be in the foreign currency or its equivalent in local currency at the prevailing official exchange rate for the location in which the staff member is based.

In case a staff member or direct relative insured under the Centre coverage has been recommended for medical evacuation and the evacuation has been endorsed by the Director General, the Centre will provide sufficient funds in foreign currency to cover the cost of medical treatment and subsistence. Funds will be provided only up to the estimated cost of medical treatment, subsistence and transportation to the nearest place where treatment can be provided.

The Centre will allow advance foreign currency for any reductions made by the insurer for self-risk or similar costs, which will be reimbursed by the staff member in cash or by salary deductions. Foreign exchange will not be granted for any amount disallowed by the insurer as not covered by the policy. All expenses must be justified upon return of the evacuated person, and unspent balances must be returned in cash or by personal cheque. Refunds may be in the foreign currency or its equivalent in local currency at the prevailing official exchange rate for the location in which the staff member is based.

Normally no foreign exchange will be issued to staff going on vacation or travelling for personal reasons.

VIII TRIP REPORTS

Staff members are required to prepare a trip report within 10 working days of return to the duty station. The trip report should be attached to the travel expense claim (TEC) and shared with the relevant supervisor. No additional travel advance will be provided for future trips until a trip report is submitted.

IX MISCELLANEOUS TRAVEL EXPENSES

For the allowed and disallowed travel expenses, refer to the Travel Guidelines.